MACBETH

ACT I. (*Thunder and lightning*.) In a desolate heath, three witches gather and decide to meet again when the battle's lost and won, and accost Macbeth who is one of the great generals in King Duncan's army. The battle the witches are talking about is a rebellion started by the traitorous Thane of Cawdor who allied with the King of Norway. Fortunately for Scotland, Macbeth and Banquo met the assaults of the enemies and defeated them with great courage. King Duncan decides to make Macbeth his new Thane of Cawdor as a reward for his valour and loyalty to Scotland and execute the previous Thane of Cawdor for his foul betrayal. On his way to meet the King, Macbeth, accompanied by his friend Banquo, meets the three witches who have been waiting for them. The three weird sisters who should be women, and yet wear beards, hail Macbeth by his current title, Thane of Glamis, then they call him Thane of Cawdor and then king. Banquo is not to be king, but his descendents will be. At first, they are not very much inclined to believe them, but when Ross and Angus come to bring them the news that Macbeth is the new Thane of Cawdor, as the witches have just foretold, the thought that he may be destined for an even greater future steals into Macbeth's soul. But alas, he is not the King's heir. Duncan has two sons, Malcolm and Donalbain, and, after greeting Macbeth and offering him the new title, he proclaims Malcolm prince of Cumberland and his heir. Then they all go to Inverness, Macbeth's castle, to celebrate the victory there, while Macbeth is secretly thinking of removing both Duncan and Malcolm out on his way to the throne. (*Inverness*. *Before Macbeth's castle*.) Lady Macbeth reads a

letter from her husband in which he tells her of the prophecy and confesses to her his secret thoughts. She however knows that Macbeth is a loyal man and he might hold his ambition back so that she is determined to urge him to murder Duncan and take the throne. “Come, you spirits / That tend on mortal thoughts, unsex me here; / And fill me, from the crown to the toe, top-full / Of direst cruelty! Make thick my blood, / Stop up the passage and access to remorse; / That no compunctious visitings of nature / Shake my fell purpose, nor keep peace between / The effect and it! Come to my woman’s breasts, / And take my milk for gall you murdering ministers, / Wherever in your sightless substances / You wait on nature’s mischief! Come, thick night, / And pall thee in the dunnest smoke of hell, / That my keen knife see not the wound it makes; / Nor heavens peep through the blanket of the dark, / To cry, ‘Hold, hold!’ ─” This is exactly what she does when Macbeth comes back home and she promises to help him. The unsuspicious and open-hearted Duncan, now a guest in his home, makes Macbeth hesitate at first, but Lady Macbeth calls him a coward and persuades him to go on with their plans. She has already devised a plot: she is to induce the king's guards to drink and Macbeth will have the opportunity to slip into Duncan's quarters, slay him, and plant the murder weapons on the drunken guards. **ACT II.** (*The same*.) Banquo’s heart is laden with gloomy thoughts and he tries to talk with Macbeth about their encounter with the witches but the latter postpones the discussion. Alone now and awaiting for the bell which is Lady Macbeth’s signal to proceed with the murder, Macbeth has a vision of the dagger that seems to show him the way to the King’s chamber. The bell rings and the murder is committed. Macbeth has killed sleep, the innocent sleep and now Macbeth shall sleep no more. A knocking on the door

frightens him and Lady Macbeth has to take him to his chambers. The knocking seems indeed a hellish noise in that stormy night, but there are only Macduff and Lennox who have come to see the King. Macbeth comes to greet them feigning to have just awoken from his sleep and lets the two lords discover the dreadful murder. Overcome by what appears to be righteous anger, Macbeth kills the two presumably guilty guards and Lady Macbeth faints, unable to bear such a horrible sight. These actions free Macbeth and his wife from suspicion, but King Duncan's sons, Malcolm and Donalbain, are not convinced that Scotland is a safe place for them and they decide to flee Macbeth's castle as a precaution against their own murder. Malcolm will head for England and Donalbain for Ireland. Their flight, however, piles accusation on them as people now think that they have paid the guards to kill the King. Now, there is nothing to stand in Macbeth's way to the throne and he is soon to be crowned King of Scotland. **ACT III**. (*An audience room in the palace at Forres*.) Banquo, the only one who was with Macbeth and saw the witches, suspects that Macbeth is the real murderer and wonders whether the prophecy concerning him will come true as well. Macbeth also worries that Banquo might become suspicious, and besides, there is that part of the prophecy in which Banquo's sons and not his are to be kings. To prevent this from happening he hires two murderers to kill Banquo and his son. They, joined by a third one, manage to kill the Scottish lord, but his son, Fleance escapes and so the witches' prophecy has not been thwarted by Macbeth, as he wanted. Macbeth is still tormented by guilt and remorse and finds it very hard to enjoy the banquet that celebrates his coronation. Lady Macbeth tries to strengthen him and convince him to forget about the murder. Things become worse when, after talking with the murderers who announce

him of their only partial success, and thinking of the implications of Fleance's escape Macbeth sees the ghost of Banquo sitting in his place and starts speaking to it in guilty horror. Lady Macbeth needs to finish their party early to prevent further suspicions about Macbeth's sanity and about their role in the recent events. Lennox, from among the lords, becomes suspicious of Macbeth's innocence and learning that Macduff also distrusts the new King, leaves for England to join Malcolm so that they both might convince the English king to provide military help against Macbeth. **ACT IV**. (*A castle in Scotland*.) The witches, joined by Hecate, prepare a deadly potion while Macbeth arrives to find out more about the future. Three apparitions, summoned by the witches, foretell what will come for him. The first one, an armed head, warns him to beware of Macduff; the second, a bloody child, tells him that no man born of a woman can kill him while the third, a crowned child holding a tree says that he will never be defeated until Birnam Wood comes to Dunsinane. Encouraged by what he has heard, Macbeth still insists on knowing if Banquo's children will be kings. This time a procession of kings appears, the last one holding a mirror in which he sees Banquo smiling. Besides this last prediction, Macbeth is satisfied with what he has just learned and thinks that only Macduff may be a threat to him whereas the other prophecies are unlikely to happen. But since Macduff has fled to England, Macbeth decides to kill his pregnant wife and his son in revenge. In England, Malcolm suspects that Macduff may have been sent by Macbeth and he tests his lord's loyalty. Being eventually convinced of Macduff's integrity, he reveals to him that an army has already been secured and they start planning their revenge against Macbeth. **ACT V**. (*Dunsinane. A room in the castle*.) Lady Macbeth is sick, she is sleep-walking and she keeps trying

to write a letter. She obsessively washes her hands and speaks about the murders. It is not much afterwards that Macbeth learns about his wife's suicide and starts pondering on the futility of life. "She should have died hereafter; / There would have been a time for such a word. / To-morrow, and to-morrow, and to-morrow, / Creeps in this petty space for day to day, / To the last syllable of recorded time; / And all our yesterdays have lighted fools / The way to dusty death. Out, out, brief candle! / Life's but a walking shadow; a poor player, / That struts and frets his hour upon the stage, / And then is heard no more: it is a tale / Told by an idiot, full of sound and fury, / Signifying nothing. –" Meanwhile, armies have gathered around the castle and the King learns that many of his Scottish noblemen have deserted him. Believing in the prophecy and since Birnam Wood does not appear to be moving he is still confident. But the Woods are moving when the soldiers, instructed by Malcolm, carry cut boughs as camouflage. Now, there is one more prophecy that gives Macbeth hopes of victory, and he dares to confront Macduff. However, fate seems to be against him once more, and Macduff tells the King that he was born by Caesarean section. Now, Macbeth is sure that everything is lost, and though sure of his imminent defeat, he refuses to cowardly surrender and is killed in fair combat. Justice is restored and Malcolm, the rightful heir of Scotland, is hailed as the new King. (IB)